

Hard and soft letter sounds

THE LETTERS *c* AND *g* CAN MAKE HARD AND SOFT SOUNDS.

The letter that follows *c* or *g* determines if a word has a hard or soft sound. This sound can occur in any part of the word, not just at the beginning.

The hard and soft *c*

The letter *c* makes a hard sound when it appears before any letter other than *e*, *i*, or *y*. A soft *c* sounds like an *s*—as in *silly*—and can be heard in words where *c* occurs before the letters *e*, *i*, or *y*.

▷ Hard “c” sounds

There are many words in English with a hard “c” sound. A word like *cartoon* has a hard “c” sound because *c* precedes the letter *a*.

cartoon
re**c**all

cow
un**c**le

crack
por**c**upine

▷ Soft “c” sounds

These words all have a soft “c” sound. The word *cereal* has a soft “c” sound because *c* precedes the letter *e*.

cereal
de**c**ent

circus
pen**c**il

cyan
fan**c**y

Words with both “c” sounds

Sometimes, one word includes a hard and a soft “c” sound. These are unusual in English; however, they do follow the same rules.

circulate
soft “c” sound → hard “c” sound

bicycle
soft “c” sound → hard “c” sound

clearance
hard “c” sound → soft “c” sound

vacancy
hard “c” sound → soft “c” sound

Most words with a **soft c** or **g** come from **Latin**.

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• Sometimes, a **word** has a **hard “c” sound** that is followed by the letter *e* or *i*. In these cases, the letter *h* is added to make the *c* hard. Some example words include **chemist** (the letter *e*) and **chiropractic** (the letter *i*).